

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Breech Presentation

When baby is in a bottom-down or feet-first position near term

WHAT IS BREECH POSITION?

A breech baby has their buttocks or feet positioned to be born first, rather than head-first (vertex). Most babies turn head-down by **36 weeks**. Breech occurs in about **3–4% of full-term pregnancies**. Many babies are breech earlier in pregnancy and turn on their own.

RISK FACTORS

- Preterm pregnancy (before 37 weeks)
- Multiple gestation (twins/triplets)
- Uterine abnormalities or fibroids
- Placenta previa
- Excess amniotic fluid (polyhydramnios)
- Previous breech baby
- Fetal abnormalities (rare)

EXTERNAL CEPHALIC VERSION (ECV)

ECV is a procedure at **36–37 weeks** where your doctor manually turns the baby from outside your belly. Performed in the hospital with monitoring. **Success rate: ~50–60%**. Medication to relax the uterus is used. Risk of complications is low but ECV is not appropriate for all patients.

TYPES OF BREECH

- **Frank breech** — buttocks first, legs extended up **Most Common**
- **Complete breech** — sitting cross-legged, bottom first
- **Footling breech** — one or both feet first
- **Transverse lie** — baby lying sideways

HOW IS IT DIAGNOSED?

- Leopold maneuvers — hands-on abdominal exam
- Ultrasound — confirms position accurately
- Usually detected at 35–36 week prenatal visit
- You may feel hard round head (kicks) near ribs
- Hiccups felt low in pelvis suggest head-down

DELIVERY OPTIONS

- **C-section** — most common recommendation for persistent breech at term; safest option for most
- **Vaginal breech delivery** — rarely offered; requires specific criteria and experienced provider
- If baby turns after ECV or spontaneously — normal vaginal birth possible
- Decisions made based on your specific situation

⚠️ WHEN TO CALL YOUR DOCTOR / GO TO LABOR & DELIVERY

- ⚠️ You feel the umbilical cord in your vagina
 - ⚠️ Vaginal bleeding at any time
 - ⚠️ Regular contractions before 37 weeks
 - ⚠️ Any concern about your baby's movement or position
- ⚠️ Decreased fetal movement after 28 weeks
 - ⚠️ Water breaks before labor starts
 - ⚠️ Sudden severe abdominal pain
 - ⚠️ Fluid leaking from vagina

♥️ Many Breech Babies Turn on Their Own!

The majority of babies who are breech before 36 weeks turn to head-down on their own. Even if your baby remains breech, you have safe, well-studied options. Whether through ECV, a planned cesarean, or a spontaneous turn, your care team will guide you toward the safest outcome for you and your baby.